DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Do the Righteous Suffer and the Wicked Prosper?

Derech Hashem 2:2:3-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 2, paragraphs 3-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

This short class was given on Pesah Sheni. The transcript is unclear in places; these notes follow what can be understood.

Recap and a clarification

The Rabbi reviewed the two kinds of providence. Hashgahah kelalit is on the species: Hashem does not care which cat is killed, only that there is the right number of cats. Hashgahah peratit is individual: Hashem cares about your actions, and humans are the only species with it.

Someone had asked him a question the week before, and he clarified: even an animal can come under individual providence when it affects a human being. If you own a dog, or a farmer owns sheep, what happens to that animal affects the person, so it falls under the person's providence. A participant gave the example of Yaakov's flocks, where Hashem ensured exactly how many sheep were born speckled and spotted, because it made a difference to Yaakov. The Rabbi called it "a fantastic example."

He then recalled paragraph 2: perfection happens on two levels, each individual and humanity as a whole. Because humanity has free choice, some will end up good and some bad, and in the end the bad must be pushed away while the good are gathered into one community that merits the World to Come. Asked whether the Ramhal means a person's deeds or the people themselves, the Rabbi said the next paragraph makes clear it means people.

Paragraph 3: the problem of mixed deeds

The same free will that makes some people good and some bad also means that most people's deeds are mixed: some good, some bad. That creates a problem. How can there be a community of the perfect when almost everyone has something bad in them?

Perhaps, one might suggest, we go by the majority: mostly good joins the good, mostly bad joins the bad. The Ramhal says that is unacceptable. That is not justice. A human might say "he's generally a good person," but for Hashem, justice dictates that every action, good or bad, great or small, must receive a response. Nothing can go unanswered. And most of us do not fully repent; most of us die with a mixture.

So Hashem's wisdom decreed that reward and punishment are divided into two times and two places. A person's deeds are divided into majority and minority. The majority is judged in its proper place, and the minority in another. If you are essentially a good person who did some bad, you belong to the community of the perfect, so your bad deeds must be dealt with somewhere else. If you are essentially bad but did some good, you will be pushed away, so your good deeds must be repaid somewhere else.

Paragraph 4: the real reward and the real punishment

"Never forget," the main reward is only in the World to Come, and the Rabbi asked everyone to pay attention to the next lines. The reward is eternal closeness and cleaving to Hashem. And what is punishment? "Punishment isn't a burning pot on fire." The ultimate punishment is being pushed away: no consciousness, nothing left of who you are.

He compared this to teachers. A teacher who tells a child off still cares about the child's development. The teacher who gives up says, "I'm not interested. He's finished." The real punishment is being given up on.

So, going by the majority: the good person enters the World to Come, and the bad person is pushed away. And the minority? This world, with its successes and its downfalls, takes care of it. The rasha, who has done some good, is rewarded in this world. The saddik's sins are atoned through suffering and affliction in this world. The result is pure justice, and the community of the World to Come is left with saddikim and no bad people among them, and even each individual has nothing bad left in him.

Questions from the group

Is the majority a matter of quantity? No. The Rabbi stressed that it is qualitative: "Don't make this mistake in thinking the more I do, the more I get." It is the quality of the actions that counts, not counting them.

Is it fair to reward the wicked in this world? The Rabbi sharpened the question. If the saddik's majority is rewarded in the World to Come, why should the rasha's good deeds be "paid off" with money, cars and comforts in this world? He said the two questions answer each other. A truly spiritual misvah, done for its own sake out of genuine belief, cannot be repaid in this world. Even a person who did many wrongs but did such a deed, for example supporting a yeshivah because deep down he believed in Torah, cannot lose that; he will go through a great tikkun to cleanse himself, but he will reach the World to Come. The rasha who is pushed away is one whose good deeds, helping this person or that, were always done for ulterior motives such as financial gain or social recognition. Those are physical deeds, and they are paid in physical currency: recognition and money. The Rabbi added that the next class would show how many mechanisms exist to bring a person into the community of the perfect.

Do not judge others. The Rabbi cautioned that we must never make these judgments about other people, measuring how successful someone is and drawing conclusions. There are so many factors and permutations that only Hashem can weigh. Even small inconveniences, such as reaching into your pocket and pulling out the wrong coin, are counted as a form of suffering.

Why does suffering atone?

The Rabbi left the group with a question: why should illness or financial loss atone for sin? What is the connection? He offered an opening, to be continued on Thursday. The Gemara in Berakhot compares suffering to the salt used to kasher meat. Just as salt draws out the blood that makes meat unfit, suffering cleanses a person. The Maharsha explains that a person sins through the energy of his blood, his vitality. When his life is not serene, whether in health or finances, that weakens him and draws it out.

Summary

- Free will means most people have mixed deeds, yet justice demands that every deed receive a response.
- So Hashem divides reward and punishment between this world and the World to Come, according to the qualitative majority of a person's deeds.
- The real reward is eternal closeness to Hashem; the real punishment is being pushed away, not fire.
- The saddik's few sins are cleansed through suffering in this world; the rasha's good deeds, done for worldly motives, are repaid with worldly reward.
- We must never judge others by their fortunes in this world.

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